

FreeBSD

What started with Unix in around 1971, is thought to have reached its pinnacle with FreeBSD. When the age of microcomputers dawned on us, there was a sore need for operating systems, and everyone was building code that was essentially what we would call apps or software today, but calling them operating systems. In 1978, if you wanted to do word processing, you could buy it from Lexitron, who would sell you a computer, and 5.5-inch floppy disks where the “OS” and word processor were essentially one and the same.

Rewind to the 1960s, and we’d love to be a fly on the wall inside Bell Labs. Watching computing history being made, as the predecessor of Unix, Multics was being developed. As it would turn out, Multics was too big and too cumbersome of a project, and had goals that seemed unattainable. Instead of working on this behemoth that was growing into something too complex to understand anymore, people started quitting the group to go work on something else instead. Eventually, everyone would quit, and the last few, Ken Thompson, Dennis Ritchie, Doug Mcilroy and Joe Ossanna decided to work on something on a much smaller scale.

Together they worked and described their goal for the new OS they wanted to build, and called it Unix. Eventually, Unix would do so well in Bell Labs that it was being used everywhere, and was even licensed out to others, including Berkley, which is where the Berkley Software Distribution (BSD) name comes from. Initially BSD was called Berkley Unix, but the name changed to BSD later, and then even that forked off in different directions.